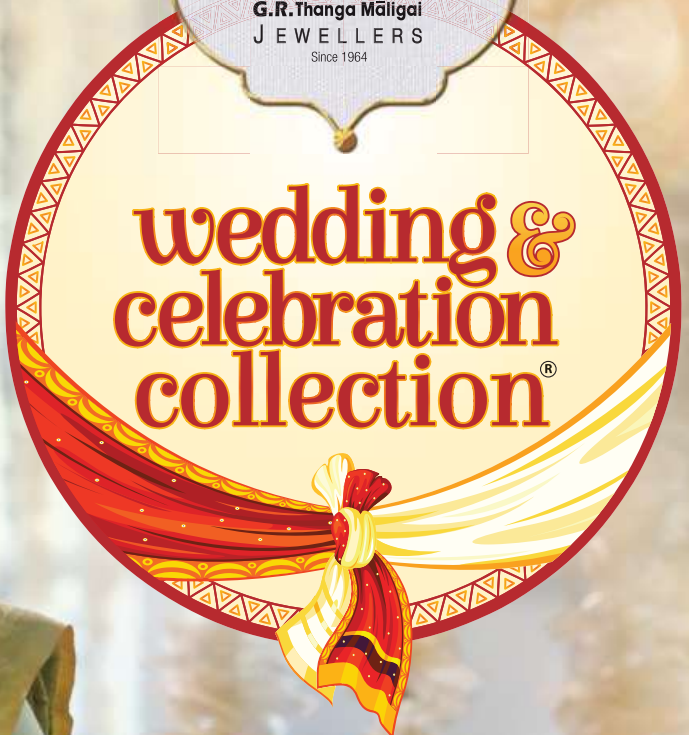








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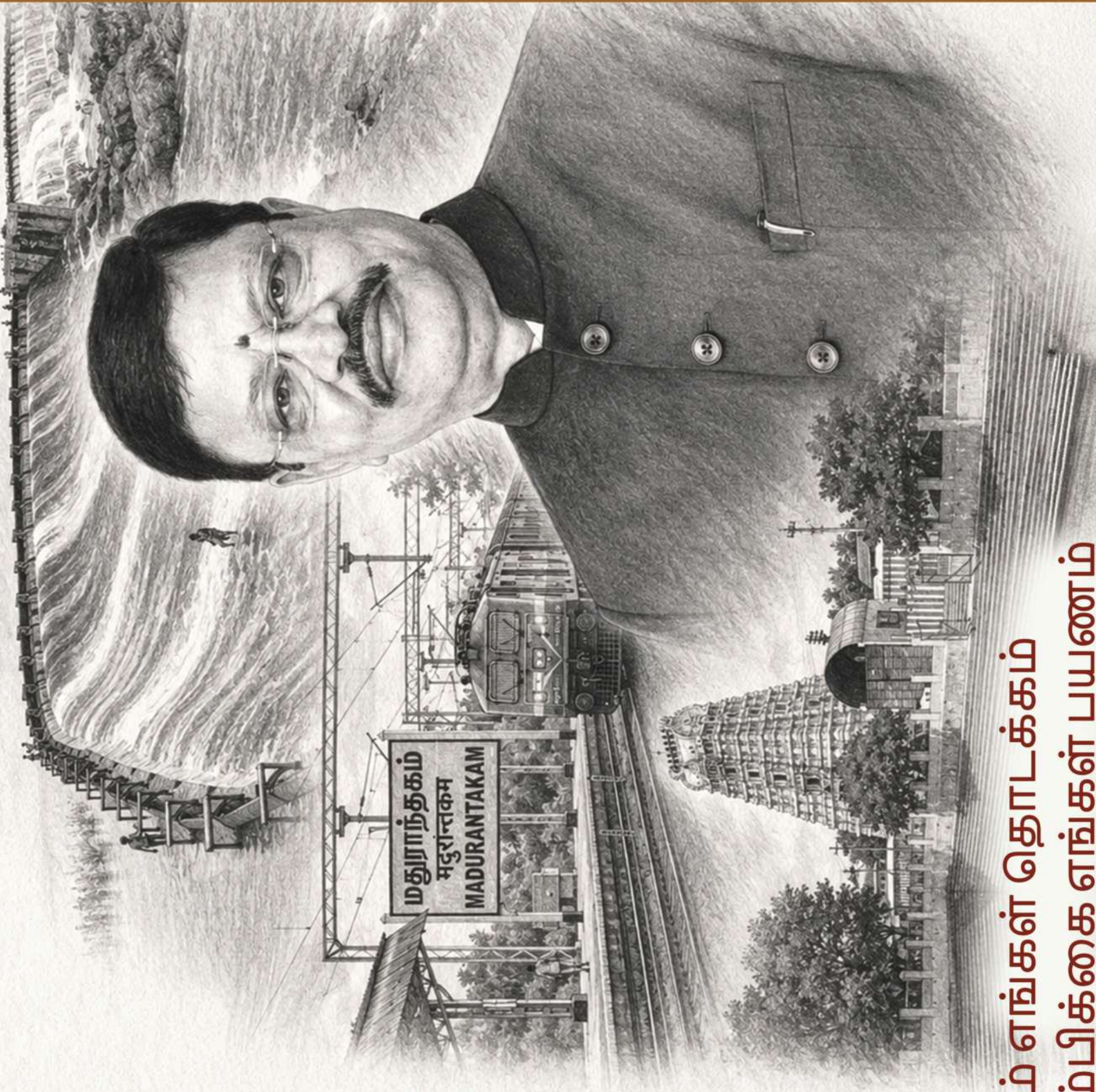


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pick of the week



For the love of cars

Vintage engines, polished chrome, and old-world charm take over Madras Day 2026. MHMC's Heritage Motoring Day rolls in on August 23 with classic cars and bikes, hands-on CPR training, a hearty ITC Grand Chola breakfast, and a display of Madras's motoring history. *Catch the action at HOI Foundation Grounds, next to Huma Hospitals, opposite YMCA College & Cosmo Golf Course, Nandanam, Mount Road, from 10am to 5pm.*



A Goa detour

South Goa's speakeasy culture is making a one-night stop in Chennai as MOFO brings its food and cocktail pop-up to the city. Known as South Goa's first speakeasy, the venue is teaming up with Tobias Carvalho and chef Mohit for an evening of cocktails, and bold food. *The pop-up will take place on August 25 from 7pm onwards at Roc-A-Coe, No. 11, KNK Road, Chennai. For reservations call 8925977804 or DM rocacoebar.che on Instagram*



Keralam on a plate

Celebrate Onam at Sangeetha Veg with a traditional sadya featuring banana chips, sarkara upperi, pachadi, thoran, kootu curry, olan, kalan, inji puli, pickles, pappadam, pazham, more kachiyathu and pradhanam. Served on a banana leaf, the festive feast brings together Kerala's signature flavours in one elaborate spread. *At Sangeetha Veg's on August 26 at Adyar, Virugambakkam and Anna Nagar outlets, from 11am to 3pm.*



All things art

Step into Echoes of Form exhibition, where silence speaks, lines remember, and light converses with shadow. Presented by Marappachism Studio & Semeion under the theme Form. Rhythm. Harmony, the show unveils quiet resonances of origin and becoming. Featuring artists include Uma Maheswari A, Dhenuka Nandhu, Reya V, and Mayurapriya. *At Labernum & Indigo Gallery, Cholomandal Artists Village till August 26, from 10am to 6pm.*



Gilded age

Designer duo Abu Jani and Sandeep Khosla expands their maximalist universe with a new store in Mumbai

Barry Rodgers

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A mythical brass city hangs upside down, an ivory shola tree blooms indoors, the Mumbai skyline becomes a gilded promenade, while an archive unfolds through the geometry of Indian stepwells. This is Mubarak Baug, Mumbai-based designers Abu Jani and Sandeep Khosla's new 20,000-square-foot Mumbai flagship – a maximalist dream that marks four decades of their couture house. Mubarak Baug is not A Wonder Room, the duo's new art and design gallery, but it offers perhaps the clearest glimpse yet

of the thinking behind it: a belief that art, craft, architecture, objects and fashion need not stay in their respective corners. Bringing together art, craft, furniture, textiles, lighting and commissioned works, the gallery allows the designers to curate, collaborate and commission beyond couture. The idea, however, is hardly new. “A Wonder Room is a universe because it is not defined by a single discipline or object,” says Sandeep Khosla. “Our goal is to bring together art, craft and culture within these curated environments, where the space itself becomes the canvas.” And Mumbai, naturally, gets a starring role. Art Deco influences run through the space, including



the Bombay Skyline Corridor, where artist Shilo Shiv Suleman has hand-embossed the city's urban sprawl onto brass panels. Photographer Viraj Nayak's wall of black-and-white Mumbai photographs adds another layer, while Wolf Jaipur turns embroidery and fabric offcuts into floor-to-ceiling sculptural panels. Then there are painted frescoes by artist Shine Shivan, conjuring mythology, architecture and fantastical landscapes. Formalising A Wonder Room as a gallery gives this instinct “a



Inside the new 20,000-square-foot store in Mumbai; and, the design duo. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

fully realised home, a discipline and a future”, he says. It also creates a platform for more deliberate collaborations with artists and craftspeople. “It is not a departure from couture. It is the next natural turn in a creative journey that has always extended far beyond fashion.”

The room as a work of art At A Wonder Room, the room itself becomes part of the work. Objects are not presented as anonymous inventory but placed within authored environments, with their provenance, context and relationship to surrounding works forming part of the experience.

That expansive approach is encapsulated in the designers' phrase 'India Maximal'. It may sound like a licence for more colour, ornament, pattern and embellishment, and, well, the duo has never exactly been accused of underdoing things, but Sandeep sees it as something



Our goal is to bring together art, craft and culture within these curated environments, where the space itself becomes the canvas

more considered. “India Maximal is often mistaken for abundance and opulence alone,” he says. “There is so much emotional depth to it. It is the freedom to use beauty fully and unapologetically.”

Keeping craft alive Craft sits at the centre of this universe, but Sandeep is wary of treating tradition as something to be preserved behind glass. “Preservation cannot just mean placing craft within a glass box. A living tradition must be practised, challenged, commissioned and given new contexts.”

A Wonder Room aims to create that exchange by bringing artists and craftspeople together as creative equals. Materials such as shola, brass, embroidery and handwoven textiles can be explored at different scales, forms and settings, while retaining the knowledge embedded in the techniques. For Sandeep, keeping craft relevant means allowing it to evolve. “For a new generation to value craft, it must encounter it as something alive, relevant and capable of surprise.” As the couture house marks four decades, Sandeep sees legacy not as an archive but as an opportunity to create new conditions for creativity.

(Clockwise from below) Yuki, Osman and the team in Chennai; suits by Lector; and the designer. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Suit yourself

In India for trunk shows at Chennai and Mumbai, Japanese designer Yuki Igarashi takes us through comfort, craftsmanship and how to pick the perfect suit

S Poorvaja

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A couple of years ago, when Osman Abdul Razak was being fitted for a suit by Yuki Igarashi, founder of Tokyo-based menswear brand Lector, he recalls being struck by how neatly Yuki's pins were arranged on his pin cushion. “As an onlooker there, I couldn't help but analyse this precision. I was told that the pins were made from katana steel, the material famously used in the swords of samurais. Even the way the pins pierce through fabric felt different,” says the fashion entrepreneur and Savile-row certified bespoke tailor from Chennai. Seeing Yuki's precision translate into his designs and garments got Osman thinking; not just about how he could take a garment of his through multiple iterations for that perfect fit, but also how he could give India a taste of the Japanese tailoring and design philosophy. Maison Madras, an

experience space curated by Osman and located above his atelier on KNK Road welcomed Yuki and his team from Lector earlier this week, for a made-to-measure trunk show, before heading to Mumbai for a similar trunk show as a part of a week-long visit to India. Yuki established Lector nearly a decade ago, with salons now in Tokyo and Kobe. “We spotlight our work with Japanese craftsmen; for many, it has become hard to continue working in this field and



we believe it is our responsibility to honour our culture,” he says. Delving into their tailoring, and what sets their signature house pattern, LC 10 apart, the designer speaks about how the focus is simply to make comfort wear and yet, stay quiet, classic and timeless. “There are subtle details, none of which stand out in your face and yet it is comfortable enough to wear all day. Many people say suits are tiring, that it feels hard to even take off the jacket by themselves. We do not want to put people off from wearing suits so we came up with this,” he says. **Classic throwback** In the age of being spoiled with options for clothes that are ready-to-wear, the designer acknowledges a slow and steady shift, especially among youngsters, to go back to the classic way of dressing. “They want to experiment with classic silhouettes; this is often influenced by them rediscovering their own roots or even being inspired by how

their grandparents used to dress,” he augurs. At Chennai and Mumbai, following one-on-one client meet-ups, suits will be made at Lector's salons in Japan and will then be shipped back to India. “Much like what I follow at my atelier, Yuki also meets with clients, and the focus here is process-driven. When we sit down and have a conversation with a client, we seek to understand their lifestyle, body type and other factors that can influence the design and tailoring in the best way possible,” Osman explains. Shoulder styles, canvas construction, lapels and more... what does one keep in mind while getting their first made-to-measure or bespoke suit made? Yuki recommends that one skips scrutinising the very minute details and instead, focusses on “following a feeling”. He says, “How does the suit make you feel... does it feel good? Rather than dressing up to get praised, wear something that you personally gravitate towards.”

Bazaar hop Chennai

Srila Chatterjee curates a joyful mix of independent labels, artisanal products and affordable art

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Baro Market is coming to Chennai with a pop-up bringing together fashion, craft, art, accessories and lifestyle products, with a focus on conscious living and handcrafted design. Curated by Srila Chatterjee, the showcase marks her third pop-up in the city. “We have put a lot of thought having gone to other places before,” says Srila. “It's our third pop-up in the city. We kind of figured out the things that Chennai audiences prefer. We worked with that in mind,” she adds.

The pop-up will bring together 19 brands, spanning women's and men's fashion, children's products, jewellery, home and lifestyle, art and food. Rather than grouping together multiple labels doing similar things, Srila says the selection is deliberately varied, with every brand bringing something different to the mix. The fashion edit includes names such as Chiu, S24 Parganas, Rimil Design, De Wardrobe, Karma Ashrama, Mayur Thakkar, Lata Sita, Wrii and Foolstop. Lata Sita, for instance, turns pre-loved saris into contemporary dresses, while Foolstop brings playful storytelling and unconventional design to handcrafted accessories like funky earrings and pendants. S24 Parganas is a Bengaluru-based artisanal apparel label founded in 2020 by Sosha Thomas and Praveen Pandaredattil. Named after West Bengal's South 24 Parganas, it works with artisans skilled in traditional aari and zardozi embroidery. The selection also makes space for men, with a brand specialising in shirts – an area Srila feels is often overlooked in such markets. The pop-up ventures into home and lifestyle with brands such as Homeland, Koorm and Nest, whose



Acrylic and pen on paper by artist Samik De; (below) an outfit by Chiu. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

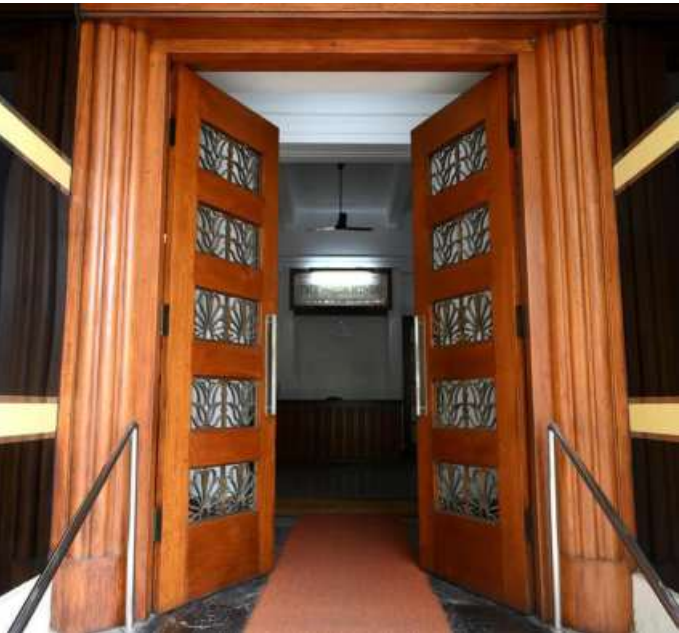
products draw on Indian craft traditions, natural materials and artisanal techniques. Art forms another part of the showcase. Srila describes an art selection from a Calcutta-based emporium, including digital prints, original works and prints of works by various masters. Some of the artists featured include Samik De, Subrata Gongopadhya, and Rajendra Malakar. “All of it is affordable,” she says, describing works that are intended to resonate with visitors and find a place in their homes, without being intimidating either in subject or price. “Every single one of our brands is hand-picked, and each one separately lends to the bazaar,” she says. The compact format is designed so visitors can easily walk around and encounter every brand. Accessibility extends across the pop-up. Prices begin at ₹700 and go up to ₹40,000, offering a wide range for shoppers and collectors alike.



From August 27 to 29 at The Folly at Amethyst, Royapettah, from 11am to 8pm.



(Clockwise from left) Dare House; *The Hindu* office's door with floral motifs; Oriental Insurance Building; inside *The Hindu* office where the typography of the lift is in Art Deco style. THAMODHARAN B AND BINSAN OOMMEN BABY



Chennai continues to host. She adds that when it comes to Madras particularly, it is not the European version of Art Deco but rather the North American version called Streamline Moderne that is extensively used. She adds that Art Deco can be found in several houses across Chennai although these are disappearing too. However, people find several ways to customise the Art Deco buildings to suit Indian sensibilities. “I have seen a house in Mylapore where there is a central bust of Mahatma Gandhi on the facade. It is because the style flourished during India's freedom struggle. This is just one such example,” she says.

Bespoke
Kapil Chitale, grandson of LM Chitale and proprietor, Chitale and Sons, one of Chennai's oldest architecture firms, says that when his grandfather built the Tamil Isai Mandram on Esplanade, he found ways to integrate a most wonderful temple-sensibility at the site. “The hall was constructed to celebrate Tamil music. It was a movement to challenge the Sanskrit and Telugu music performed at many other sabhas like the Music Academy. It is why the motifs and the embellishments on the pillars would be distinctly Tamil in nature,” says Sujatha. Thirupurasundari Sevvel, architect, and historian, says that one can find such

examples back at *The Hindu* office too. “If we really think about it, Kasturi Buildings is an Indo-deco structure. Several customisations have taken place, keeping with the style of the original building. It is why the grandeur of the structure remains. Inside *The Hindu* office, you will find mixed floors, polished stairways, and hallways that carry its own colour and mood. A mint green, pink, and a gold, each suited for a different floor,” she says. After spending a day hunting for Art Deco elements on *The Hindu* office's premises and pouring through the archives at Chitale and Sons, a couple of conclusions clearly emerge. Bold black glass piers banded in cream, grilles catching the light, a sweeping cantilever canopy jutting out to greet visitors, geometric iron work too, clean confident lines – it is the same grammar that you will spot across Chennai's Art Deco buildings even today. The style that eventually gave way to the international style or modernism, continues to delight. Even today, behind the ornamental front, lie halls full of journalists, bankers, agents, and employees, spending hours, hoping to provide meaning to their big little lives. The truth is that Art Deco was never just about decoration. It was about function and and how a city tells its stories.

Lines of legacy

CONTINUED FROM
» PAGE 1

Sujatha Shankar, architect and convener, INTACH, Chennai Chapter, says that picking her favourite Art Deco building in the city is like having to pick a favourite child. “I really like the LIC Building on Esplanade. It's got symmetry, a tall elegant entrance, soaring verticals, fins, ziggurat-like crowning feature, Aztec-like features. It's an amazing rendering of Art Deco,” she says, adding



that Dare House in Parry's is another favourite. “This building has the curved corner where two roads (here NSC Bose Road and Rajaji Salai) now meet. It has pins and pistons on top, both fabulous elements, indicating the industrialisation of the era.” Ashmitha Athreya, trustee, Madras Inherited, says that when people come on walks that the organisation conducts, they are often surprised by the sheer number of buildings that

Walk into Kasturi Buildings, *The Hindu*'s headquarters on Anna Salai to revel in its Art Deco heritage, and to check out Madras On Stage, an archival photo exhibition drawn from *The Hindu*'s vast archives till September 10. The exhibition traces Chennai's cultural life through performances, conversations, festivals, and everyday gatherings.

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Madras, made together

AU Small Finance Bank (AU SFB) has partnered with *The Hindu*'s Made of Chennai as a Co-Powered Partner for this year's city-wide celebration, themed 'Madras on the Move'. The association brings together the bank's focus on community, participation and accessible financial experiences with a month-long programme celebrating Chennai's heritage, culture and people. As part of the partnership, AU SFB will support key Made of Chennai experiences, including the Moonlight Cinema, Archival Photo Exhibition, Made of Chennai Run, Saree Walk and Food & Music Festival. The bank will create interactive engagement zones across these events, including a photo booth built around the campaign thought 'Made of People. Made of Chennai', cashless payment experiences through AU prepaid cards and digital participation initiatives. AU SFB will also present The Madras Affair, a curated cultural evening at Taj Connemara, bringing together business leaders, heritage families, cultural patrons and other voices from the city. The evening will feature storytelling circles, conversations with cultural custodians, live performances, art installations and heritage-inspired culinary experiences. “Through Made of Chennai, we hope to build meaningful connections with the city's communities while making participation more accessible and engaging,” says Uttam Tibrewal, deputy CEO Retail Banking, AU Small Finance Bank.



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Sounds off script

Chennai's indie scene is getting another night to remember as Permanent Vacation returns for its second edition. The line-up brings together four independent acts, each with a sound of its own. The Siennor Trio serves up storytelling-led art-pop, Blues Conscience brings 17 years of blues, groove and high-energy performances, The Broadway Addicts turn up the punk-infused alternative rock, while Srie's BessyBop blends alt-pop and jazz-pop into something wonderfully hard to categorise. Expect original music, big energy and lots of nostalgia. On August 29 at *The Spotted Deer*, Hotel Palomar. Tickets on fanpit.live

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Reality star and business mogul Kim Kardashian has spent much of her career being told that her body was the product. With Skims, she figured out how to make the product the business.

Founded with Jens Grede in 2019, Skims began with shapewear and underwear and has since expanded into loungewear, menswear, swim, and activewear. In November 2025, the company raised \$225 million at a \$5 billion valuation (roughly ₹41,500 crore), with projected 2025 net sales of more than \$1 billion (roughly ₹8,300 crore).

Now, that proposition is coming to India. On August 5, Reliance Brands announced an exclusive partnership with Skims. The first stores will open in Mumbai and Delhi soon.

“The excitement we’ve seen from our community in India has been truly incredible,” Kim said in the announcement. Isha Ambani, director, Reliance Retail Ventures, said Skims had “changed how the world thinks about shape, comfort and inclusivity”, adding that the brand speaks to a generation of Indian

The big shape-up

Kim Kardashian is bringing Skims to India. But, homegrown shapewear brands believe they have one advantage: knowing Indian bodies better

consumers who want fashion that is “aspirational and made for them.”

That last bit – made for them – is where the India story gets interesting. Because Skims is entering a market where Indian brands have spent years, trying to answer a specific question: what does shapewear look like when the body underneath it isn’t a Western sample size?

Skims may have the Kardashian effect, but Indian shapewear isn’t exactly waiting for a teacher. “You cannot school the teacher; she is the teacher!” says Pankhuri Harikrishnan, founder and director of Delhi-based communication and brand experience agency Fetch Consulting, of Kim’s ability to turn product marketing into

cultural conversation. But Pankhuri also pushes back on the idea that Indian shapewear is still primarily a wedding purchase. “I do not think weddings largely drive the market.” The bigger shift, she says, is towards launches, events and everyday occasions when consumers want to look and feel their best.

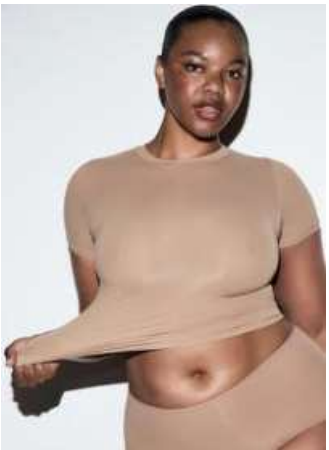
For Anjali Gaekwar, Mumbai-based luxury brand advisor and co-founder of Lighthouse, a boutique retail and lifestyle advisory firm, that evolution is part of a broader premiumisation of the category. “The premium consumer isn’t buying a foundational garment anymore; she’s buying an invisible layer of craftsmanship.” The opportunity, she

believes, is increasingly in everyday shapewear that can disappear beneath tailoring, knitwear, saris and kurtas.

The India opportunity
The opportunity, then, is not just to sell more shapewear. It is to convince Indian consumers that shapewear belongs in the wardrobe in the first place, and that it can be worth paying more for.

Indian brands have already been doing that work. Kamakshi Agarwala, founder and CEO of Butt-Chique, started the company in 2020, after struggling to find shapewear that worked for her own plus-size body. She says international sizing did not adequately account for the proportions she encountered among Indian women,

Skims will enter the Indian market with its body-conscious fit, wide size range, and shapewear-to-wardrobe universe. INSTAGRAM/SKIMS



particularly fuller lower bodies. Butt-Chique developed its own size chart through repeated fittings and testing. “Even the lightest shade is not your Indian lightest shade,” Kamakshi says.

Underneat, the shapewear and intimates brand founded by content creator Kusha Kapila and Vimarsh Razdan in 2025, is a useful example of how quickly the market is developing. The brand was built around products for

Indian body types and local dressing habits, including a sari-specific shaper.

The price difference with Skims is significant. UnderNeat’s current shapewear runs from around ₹899 for a high-waist brief to ₹2,299 for a brief bodysuit, with its saree shapewear at ₹1,199 and most bodysuits and shaping shorts between roughly ₹1,799 and ₹2,299. Its size range, like Butt-Chique, extends to 5XL.

Skims, by comparison, sits considerably higher internationally. Its Cool Shapewear High-Waisted Short is currently \$78, or roughly ₹6,500, in the US.

Preeti Sukhtankar, founder, The Label Life, the Mumbai-based online lifestyle brand, has been wearing shapewear for around two decades. Her verdict is telling: she owns Skims, but prefers the Underneat shapewear she bought herself. “The material is sort of thicker and it has a band with the elastic, which doesn’t allow you to roll it off,” she says. With Skims, she has found the opposite. “It doesn’t do anything. It doesn’t shape.” For someone with 20 years of shapewear experience, that is a useful reminder that celebrity and

design can only take a foundation garment so far. Eventually, it has to stay up.

Reliance, meanwhile, is hardly a newcomer to intimatewear. The group has been steadily building its position in the category: Reliance Retail acquired Zivame in 2020, took over the Amante business in 2021, and in March 2022 acquired an 89% stake in Clovia for ₹950 crore.

That makes the Skims deal strategically neat. Skims brings cultural cachet and global brand equity; Reliance brings distribution, physical retail, digital reach and years of experience selling intimate apparel in India.

Skims has also made inclusivity one of the foundations of its global identity. But there is an inherent tension in the proposition. Can a brand challenge narrow beauty standards while selling garments designed to smooth, sculpt and reshape the body?

Hitanshi Kamdar, a London-based e-commerce editor who grew up in Mumbai, has lived through that contradiction herself. She first tried shapewear about four years ago, after initially resisting it as a Gen Z consumer raised amid the body-positivity movement and the backlash against the ultra-thin beauty ideal of the 2000s. Today, she uses it differently. “I like the idea of being able to fit into shapes and silhouettes the way they were designed to be worn,” she says.

That distinction – between concealment and styling – is important. Hitanshi owns two Skims pieces, including a light-compression bodysuit and a Seamless Sculpt brief, and says they “really cinch in” her waist, smoothing lines under fitted clothes. But she also finds the compression demanding. Getting into it, she says, is “a little bit of a workout.” She still prefers M&S for lighter, everyday compression.

Skims will almost certainly remain premium. But it could make shapewear more aspirational. It could also force Indian brands to compete harder on fit, fabrication, packaging and storytelling.



Celebrating everyday forms

Mumbai-based jewellery house Sajjante brings Pret, its contemporary ready-to-wear collection, to Chennai. Founded by master goldsmith and designer Sajil Shah, the brand approaches jewellery through form, proportion, balance, and craftsmanship. Drawing from architecture, Nature, geometry and movement, the jewels range from pared-back forms to playful, sculptural designs. The collection starts from ₹1.2lakh onwards. *The collection will be showcased on August 22 at Pullman, Anna Salai from 11am to 7pm. For more information call 81047 69492*



A sandhai for the senses

Sahanas – Art Your Way brings back the spirit of the old sandhai (shanty) with its third edition of Sunday Sandhai, Manam, a marketplace celebrating fragrance, flavour, craft and community. The event features independent brands including Rooster Perfumes, Kawaaii Cosmetics, Aurakind Wellness, Kraft Collective, Yettu Coffee, Purple Brewery, Melt Co and Idaten Chocolates. Visitors can discover handmade products, meet founders, sample treats and enjoy interactive experiences, including free candle-making and pottery workshops for children. The event will be inaugurated by Janaki Sabesh, Siddharth Chandrashekar, chef Goku, Janani Kannan and Rekha Raghavendra. *On August 23, at Sahanas, Abiramapuram, from 10am to 8pm. Entry is free.*

(Clockwise from right) Gaia(2026); Animus Mundi (2018); and Bharti Kher. PETER KELLEHER, DAVID LEVENE AND JEETIN SHARMA



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When artist Bharti Kher moved to India in 1993, it changed the way she saw and perceived art. Born and raised in London, Bharti’s move to India opened up a new way of looking at identity, culture, material and memory – ideas that would go on to shape some of the most significant works in contemporary art in India and abroad.

Bharti has lived in Delhi for close to 30 years now, spending much of her adult life in India, and says the experience of moving between countries has fundamentally shaped her practice. “I am from multiple places, and I think that’s something that comes clearly through my work,” she says. “It’s like your vision is wider in some ways. You’re neither from this place nor from that. You don’t stand with strong identity, ties, allegiances.” For Bharti, that position has eventually become liberating. “I like the expression neither nor,” she says. “I always felt like I’m somewhere sort of in the middle.”

Her experience in India, particularly in Delhi, also taught her to look closely. She describes



arriving in a new country as being similar to travelling: you observe, listen and gather clues.

Her works often bring together everyday objects, found materials, mythology and surreal elements, objects with lived histories that become something else. “Materiality is central to how I make,” she says. “I believe that objects carry energy and memory and historicity and residue from their experiences being here as much as we do,” she adds.

The divine feminine
The idea of that transformation also runs through her ongoing exhibition at the Victoria and

Albert Museum in London. Bringing together four of her works created between 2008 and 2026, the exhibition is primarily installed across the Dorothy and Michael Hintze Sculpture Galleries at V&A South Kensington, with *Gia* (2026) placed at the museum’s entrance in the Exhibition Road Courtyard.

Gia is a four-foot-tall sculpture; the work depicts a female warrior who carries a home on her head. The hybrid Mother Earth goddess embodies ideas of shelter, belonging and home. The house represents the universal symbol of safety. What keeps coming up in most of her sculptures is the

divine ‘feminine’, with nostalgia also playing a very significant role.

Yet Bharti insists that her works are not simply attempts to preserve the past. “I think I’m building futures actually, not the past,” she says. “You carry the past with you. And that’s inevitable because that creates the language from which you build it.”

“The goddesses I make have always held this territory for me – the feminine as both nurturing and terrifying. She can be fertile, and she can be destructive. Cosmic and interpersonal, all at once. I’m drawn to this resistance

to fixed definitions – more interested in things becoming than in certainty, or reference to past, present, or future,” she says.

The sacred tree

That same philosophy will extend to Australia this year, when she unveils *Tree of Life*, a seven-metre-tall bronze sculpture commissioned for Powerhouse Parramatta in Sydney that is set to open on November 7. The work will be among the first major commissions for the new museum development and will stand in the entry plaza. Conceived as a spirit work, it draws on the sacred tree, one of the oldest images in Indian mythology, with heads of ancestors layered over one another to form a towering totem.

Bharti says the project has been around three and a half years in the making. The artist traces its presence across Indian and Persian mythology and Sufism. She was also inspired by Aboriginal totem structures of Australia.

“I felt that if I could stack heads of different people from different communities and different places, it almost feels like coming together in a gathering. So you talk about diversity, culture, and people together,” she adds. For Bharti, making art ultimately means remaining comfortable with uncertainty. She goes to the studio every day, works with her team and deliberately creates problems she can then attempt to solve. “I love solving problems,” she says. “So it’s just something I like, making impossible things.”

Her ongoing exhibition can be found at the Dorothy and Michael Hintze Sculpture Galleries at V&A, South Kensington, till Feburary 2027.



Srinagar, swiftly

Explore Srinagar with this itinerary covering Dal Lake at sunrise, Jamia Masjid, Khanqah-e-Moula, Lal Chowk, Asia's largest tulip garden, and an authentic wazwan

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Hailing from the South of the country, I believed my sole encounter with Kashmir would be through Hindi films. However, that did not stop me from relishing this paradise on earth, as I traverse through a city, where the past coexists with the present, carrying forward remnants of horror, heritage and honour. Here's how I spent a weekend in Srinagar.

DAY 1

2pm | Visit Jamia Masjid
Placed in contrast to the bustling streets of downtown Srinagar, the 600-year-old Jamia Masjid's architecture deviates from the usual Islamic structural tendencies, owing to the absence of domes and minarets. The mosque exhibits

Hellenic features, supported by 378 intricately carved deodar pillars that are 14 metres high.

4pm | Shopping at Lal Chowk

A visit to Srinagar is incomplete without a stopover at Lal Chowk, named after the Red Square in Moscow, Russia, by Sikh Leftist and intellectual, BPL Bedi. The iconic clock tower, or *ghanta ghar*, looms over the area, surrounded by lanes that extend on all sides. Pick up wool, tweed, or cotton pherans worn by men, women and children from the stores that line the narrow streets of Lal Chowk. Pashmina and Cashmere shawls and stoles can also be found there. Stop at Crème by Ahdoos for pastries, ranging from a flaky walnut tart to eclairs and savoury puffs.

7pm | Explore Khanqah-e-Moula (Great Khanqah)
A 15-minute walk through the Zaina Kadal-Khan Kah Road, from the

Check into Radisson Collection Hotel & Spa, Riverfront Srinagar

Located along the banks of the Jhelum River, with a view of the Zabarwan mountains, the hotel's architecture combines the grandeur of a European alpine estate with traditional Kashmiri design features. The hotel marked Radisson Collection's debut project in India in 2024. "Srinagar has a distinctive cultural identity, remarkable heritage, and stories worth experiencing. Few destinations embody these qualities as authentically as this city," says Shubhankar Jyoti, general manager of the hotel. "It was designed to immerse guests in the spirit of Kashmir through thoughtful design, curated local experiences and genuine hospitality, allowing travellers to discover the destination in an authentic and meaningful way," adds Shubhankar.

(Clockwise from left) An aerial view of Srinagar; Indira Gandhi Memorial Tulip garden; shikaras lined alongside Dal Lake; wazwan from Radisson's Firdaus; Jamia Masjid; a shikara on the Dal Lake. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT, IMRAN NISSAR AND NAINU OOMMEN



Jamia Masjid, leads you to the Khanqah-e-Moula, one of the oldest Sufi shrines in Kashmir.

DAY 2

6am | Shikara ride through the Dal Lake

Shikaras made of deodar wood are docked and ready to go at Nehru Gate. The thinly-cushioned rowboat



with its unique, pointed end cuts through the waters smoothly as it moves towards the Zabarwan Range. The shikara ride through the Dal Lake is a soothing experience if you can leave by 6am. Flanked by floating shops, we pause by the kahwa vendors who serve us piping hot cups of the Kashmiri tea, garnished with saffron strands and crushed almonds. Boats serving plates of steaming hot instant noodles also await customers. Dal Lake is also home to a floating vegetable and flower market.

11am | Visit the Indira Gandhi Memorial Tulip garden

Considered the biggest tulip garden in Asia, this is situated at the foothills of the Zabarwan mountains. Boasting over 18 lakh blooming tulips of over 70 varieties and nearly one lakh other bulbous flowers, it spreads over an area of 30 hectares.

4pm | Savour fudge at Moonlight The Walnut Fudge Shop

Founded in 1896 by Ghulam Mohammed, the flagship sweet is prepared with a secret recipe containing Kashmir's walnuts, honey, and dates. Filled with crunchy walnut bits, the fudge has a dense chewy texture with a thin pastry base.

7.30pm | Wazwan dinner at Firdaus at Radisson Collection Hotel & Spa, Riverfront Srinagar

The feast consists of back-to-back courses of meat served on a bed of aromatic long-grain rice. Prepared by experienced executive chef Naresh Kharbanda, using traditional techniques and locally sourced ingredients, the dinner showcased the depth and complexity of Kashmiri flavours. The Tabak Maaz, a lamb rib dish delicately falls off the bone, the subtly spiced aab ghosht, aromatic gushtaba, rista and phirni lull me into a food coma.

The writer was in Srinagar on the invitation of Radisson Collection Hotel & Spa, Riverfront Srinagar.

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|| JAI SHRI RAM ||

-
- A photograph of a temple's interior. In the center is a main altar with a statue of Lord Venkateswara and his consorts, adorned with garlands and a red cloth. To the left and right are side shrines with statues of other deities. The walls are white with gold trim. A large orange arrow is superimposed on the left side of the image, pointing towards the right.

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- Lord Adinath (Rishab Dev) Temple
- Lord Anantnath Temple at GolaGhat
- Lord Sumantnath Temple at Ramkot
- Lord Ajitnath Temple near Saptsagar
- Lord Abhinandannath Temple, Sarai

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Tamil

This can make paint-drying look tempting



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After the success of his 2023 actioner, *Mark Antony*, actor Vishal must have sat and imagined a follow-up masala film that would best the Adhik Ravichandran directorial. I say this with confidence because his latest film, *Magudam* (which also marks the actor's directorial debut), is a textbook example of what could go wrong when you try to ape a winning formula. Having picked a story written by director Ravi Arasu, the producer Vishal seems to have motivated the aspiring writer-director Vishal to ensure that a checklist of tropes that worked in the recent past is in the film.

The father-son double action in *Mark Antony*? Take it, and retain those colourful costumes and some quirks. Is seaport smuggling involved? Okay, but too many such films about drug and ammunition smuggling have come out. Change it to duplicate automobile parts that cause many fatal accidents – we also get something resembling a message. Now, add some token fem-rage for good measure; something for family audiences, right? Give the father character a Robin Hood-esque gangster flashback. Let the son have a *Thevar Magan*-esque arc. Voila! You have *Magudam* (meaning 'crown' in Tamil). Oh wait, why leave Ilaiyaraaja? Let's use his songs randomly to become the one-millionth Tamil film in recent times to nostalgia-bait. This three-hour-long gangster saga is a terribly contrived and amateurish actioner.

Magudam is also one of the worst-edited films in recent times – something you would not expect from NB Srikanth. After a tiring day as a medical rep, Kirubakaran comes home to his angry wife. We get individual shots of him switching off his bike, removing his shoes, adjusting his tie, washing his hands, and settling to eat. You wonder why, for over 40 unnecessarily stretched-out minutes, we follow the harsh realities of a middle-class man's dream to buy a car, only for it to go absolutely nowhere. One imagines this might have to do with that whole 'message' at the climax about illegal imports of automobile parts, but the two-and-a-half-hour-long gangster plot between these two ideas begs to differ.

The story is essentially a demonstration of the infamous dead-wife trope – we see Kiruba suffer a tragedy that unleashes his inner beast, after which we get a flashback about how Kiruba's father, Linga, became a dreadful don controlling the Visakhapatnam port.

This is a film with terrible scene staging. In the second half, Vishal attempts to bring some emotional gravitas by using a tape recorder as a Macguffin. None of the villains feels like a real threat, and after a point, nothing makes sense anymore. Over three long hours, *Magudam* manages to do something many bad films couldn't: make film-watching feel like a punishment.

Magudam is currently running in theatres



A wholesome entertainer

Venky Atluri's *Vishwanath and Sons* is a satisfying family entertainer with some progressive ideas and standout performances

Tamil

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In Venky Atluri's charming family entertainer, *Vishwanath & Sons* (VAS), Suriya plays a middle-aged man who lives within a self-built cocoon, even when everything around him is as lavish and grand as in a materialistic man's wet dream. Among the things Sanjay Vishwanath (Suriya), a business tycoon and an Olympic-medallist shooter, inherits from his father, Vijay Vishwanath (Rajiv Menon), are a business empire, a mantra to fight till the end, and deep insecurity about marital relationships. With this complicated father-son relationship at its core, director Venky Atluri's family drama ends up as a well-written, larger-than-life entertainer that not only feels wholesome, but also bats for the right progressive registers.

The way the rousing introduction of Suriya's Sanjay is written tells you this is not going to be your routine hero vehicle. About to compete in the finals of the Paris Olympics 2024, Sanjay's locker is vandalised by unknown men; his pistol is shattered, and his jersey is torn. Sanjay remembers what his late father taught him – when something gets broken, try your best to fix it, and opt for a new one only if repairing is not possible. Sanjay fixes his pistol and, using the very same spray can used to vandalise his locker, he writes 'India' on his jersey and steps out for the game. On the surface, this is a 'mass' moment for a star's entry, but on a deeper level, this tells you who Sanjay is, how much his father meant to him, and therefore, why he has become who he is after what happened with his father.

Throughout the film, we see Sanjay do just what his father taught him to – he puts his heart into finding solutions to every issue that arises. Very attached to his mother, Nirmala Devi (Radhika Sarathkumar), Sanjay, a bachelor in his forties, finally listens to her plea for an heir to the family: he fathers a child through surrogacy. When the child,

Vishwanath and Sons

Director: Venky Atluri

Cast: Suriya, Mamitha Baiju, Radhika Sarathkumar, Raveena Tandon

Storyline: A wealthy, emotionally guarded Olympic shooter who has sworn off marriage finds his carefully ordered life upended when the surrogate mother of his ailing son enters his family and falls in love with him



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named Abhay, ends up in a hospital with a bone marrow disorder, he tracks down the surrogate mother, Maddy (Mamitha Baiju), and brings her home since her bone marrow can help cure the child. Now, what if Maddy, after spending many months with Sanjay and his family, falls in love with him? Will he confront his deep insecurities? Even if that is possible, will he agree to marry someone who is 20 years younger than him? This forms the rest of the story of VAS.

Sanjay gets to do all the above and more because...well, he can. Wealth is Sanjay's superpower, and you begin to wonder if he might end up buying the whole city to suit his needs. And the film too doesn't hide it; every pixel screams money, and every shot revels in lavishness. The storytelling, therefore, feels too convenient at times. But Venky hardly attempts to hide this. *VAS* is essentially a Bruce Wayne story; in fact, I couldn't stop chuckling when Sanjay almost buys a hotel to teach the hotel owner's rich brat son a lesson. Yet, despite this convenience, the story of *Vishwanath & Sons* is so grounded in genuine emotions that you willingly live this dreamlike life – and gladly, all this opulence ensures most other real-world problems do not obstruct Venky's narrative goals.

This also means Sanjay inadvertently spoils Maddy with his money. She calls him 'Santa Claus', making it more convenient for Maddy to see him as a potential partner. Don't get me wrong; I don't mean to say that materialistic wealth is all Maddy wants, but the text doesn't hide that she is aware of how easily she would attain most of her life's goals with Sanjay by her side. In an earlier scene, she spells out her goals for every decade of her life to someone who could realise them all in a second. But that isn't why Maddy loves Sanjay, and that's where *VAS* comes into its own.

Emotional beats accrue meaning seamlessly. Abhay and Nirmala (who Maddy calls Mrs Nirmala) become the family Maddy has been searching for her whole life, and Mamitha Baiju gives so much life to her character through her superb performance. Her very splashing entrance gives the film an instant boost of

energy, and she easily charms her way into our hearts. Of course, some generic ideas – like when Sanjay becomes a saviour to Maddy's damsel in distress or a random legal battle that goes nowhere – could have been avoided in a film that largely manages to package the right kind of commercial elements.

Vishwanath & Sons has some of the most progressive ideas that a big star vehicle could accommodate. Suriya deserves huge credit for consistently being this green-flag star, paving a progressive path for the next-generation heroes. In *VAS*, which obviously bats for the freedom to choose surrogacy, Sanjay travels to different countries on a particular date each month to satisfy his carnal desires with strangers he meets on dating apps. What's more baffling is how casually this whole idea is treated.

Venky manages to direct Suriya's easy charm and charismatic presence into something aspirational. At every major juncture in the story, Suriya is convincing as an affectionate man, but with an invisible shield around him. Watch him in the many conversations he has with Maddy in his car. GV Prakash Kumar's music breathes fresh life into *VAS*, and the film's dance choreography also catches your eye. Meanwhile, Radhika Sarathkumar reminds us who the veteran of the cast is; in a single shot where Maddy reveals her feelings for Sanjay, Radhika expresses so many different emotions in such a short span.

All that said, this is a Venky Atluri film at the end of the day, and the director displays tremendous narrative control. The ease with which every scene flows into the next feels so satisfying. As a writer, Venky shows a lot of maturity, especially in how he ends the film. On the surface, it might feel like a cop-out, but having clearly witnessed where Sanjay and Maddy stand, any other ending might have felt contrived. It also satisfyingly shows what a healthy relationship that respects boundaries would feel like. And such thoughtful writing in a mainstream hero vehicle can be rare. This is good pure-genre masala cinema.

Vishwanath and Sons is currently running in theatres

Emraan Hashmi's faded sequel doesn't rise from the riches of its past

Hindi

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Ever since its release in 2007, *Awarapan* lived as a ghost. It was spoken about more and watched less. Its protagonist, Shivam (Emraan Hashmi), became an emblem of loneliness and love and was immortalised with his sacrifice. Seeing the death of his love shattered his spirits; preserving her memory infused in him the will to live. That's what separated him from Kim Sun-woo (Lee Byung-hun), the charming, no-nonsense protagonist of the sentimental South Korean thriller, *A Bittersweet Life*, which inspired the unofficial remake of *Awarapan*. However, even with an adapted structure, director Mohit Suri and writer Shagufta Rafique breathed new life into the 2007 film, with its moving, musical rumination on faith as a pathway to healing and love as the seed of liberation.

In contrast, the sequel overlooks



what made Shivam compelling in the first place. His supposed death at the end of the first part while uniting two lovers carried a touch of the divine. It became an epochal sacrifice, washing away the sins of his past and uniting him with his beloved in paradise. However, Shivam didn't die, as the sequel tells us. Decades after the fatal day, he now lives a silent life in the Indian countryside, still bearing the pain of getting separated from Aaliyah (Shriya Saran) as he visits her grave and questions the meaning of his existence. The evolution of

Shivam's state of mind in the glorious climax of *Awarapan* is swiftly ignored. Rather, he becomes his own archetype.

There's more focus on his exteriors. His revival is explained in passing without ever delving into what fundamentally changed in his personality, apart from his slick biceps. So, Shivam remains chained to the person he was in the first part, a version that refused to fade away from the hearts of anyone who saw the film.

He is given a mission to rescue a

bunch of abducted children and save them from the dangers of human trafficking. One of them was found by him near Aaliyah's grave, after which he gave her the same name. "I won't let Aaliyah die again," he tells an Interpol officer, who seeks his help to crack the gangster web in Bangkok, managed by rivals – Shabana Azmi's mysterious boss woman, Nafeesa, and the ruthless Zoravar (Puran Gabbu). Caught in the middle of Zoravar's violence is his sister Zara (a refreshing Disha Patani), whose pain finds expression in the notes of the cello, sprawling back memories of *A Bittersweet Life*. *Awarapan 2* recalls the South Korean film on another occasion, reimagining an iconic moment of arranging parts of a dismantled gun and taking the first hit.

What it forgets to inherit from both, however, is the monumentality of emotions that Shivam and Sun-woo carry within. So, even if the action sequences have improved multifold, the lighting has become better equipped at capturing contrast, and the camera offers visuals to marvel over, the film struggles to hold itself

together as it imagines the world of *Awarapan* purely as a generic genre piece, when its soul lies elsewhere. Mohit Suri's absence is strongly felt when 'To Phir Aao' is heard without any powerful sequence to complement its evocative charm. On the other hand, 'Tere Mera Rishta Purana' still creates a soul-stirring effect when it plays at a pivotal juncture, sealing a pre-climactic

Awarapan 2

Director: Nitin Kakkar

Cast: Emraan Hashmi, Disha Patani, Shabana Azmi, Suvinder Vicky, Vijayant Kohli, Puran Gabbu

Synopsis: An Interpol officer seeks the help of Shivam Pandit to rescue a bunch of abducted kids, one of whom is the three-year-old Aaliyah, named by Shivam after his long-dead lover.

moment with Emraan's assured presence.

The actor's face brings back the specificity of Shivam's pain even after all these years. He carried the weight of *Awarapan*'s diverse themes with a rare fluidity. He does the same here, and there's a constant feeling of not being able to see him go beyond due to the limitations in the screenplay, which renders even Shabana Azmi into an awkward mould, made to blurt Urdu dialogues as she wears a witch-like costume. She deserved better, and so did Emraan, whose bad-boy romance films in the late 2000s generated a separate fan base. *Awarapan* was among the few where his character had an instant likeability factor. His image of a "serial-kisser" gave way to a charming, sensitive core. He is as sincere nineteen years later as *Awarapan 2* makes him captive to conventions rather than liberating him with subversions. Now, who's going to rescue the rescuer?

Awarapan 2 is currently running in theatres

